

Staff Commendations

March 2026

Thank you to Joyce Dutton on the donation of beautifully knitted scarves to have on hand for our students. The generosity of community members like Joyce mean a lot to all of us at DCG.

-Kristin Clayton

I would like to recognize Ashley Peterson for the amazing support she gave to keep our room running when a teacher had to leave. She kept everything running smoothly and made the day successful. You are truly an amazing part of our team.

-Kari Traver

I would like to shout out to Jorge Maldonado! I vote for a raise for him!

He is humble, kind and does his job well! He gets here to school before most of us even leave our driveways. Jorge does his job without complaining. I have done his job before and it is not easy. Props to Jorge for his good attitude day in and day out at DCG Middle School!

-Kelly McCoy

I would like to shout out to Courtney Anderson for her responsiveness to student needs at Heritage. Courtney has been pushing in behavior support into a grade level's morning meeting to provide additional social emotional learning lessons tailored to the specific needs of the students in the classroom. She displays flexibility in designing and providing a variety of behavior intervention supports for individual students. She is always one call away to provide responsive counseling services for students who are struggling with their behaviors or emotions in the moment. She is constantly willing to drop what she is doing to support others and Heritage is a better place because she is here! :)

-Jordan Paup

I would like to celebrate Cindy Armstrong for her diligent use of student data to continually fine-tune her instruction for her preschool students. She is always looking for ways to strengthen student learning and thoughtfully provides the differentiated instruction needed for each child to be successful. Cindy creates a classroom environment that is calm, welcoming, and supportive, ensuring that every student feels safe and ready to learn. Her intentional approach to instruction and commitment to meeting students' individual needs truly makes a difference in the growth of her young learners. DCG is fortunate to have Cindy as an instructional leader whose dedication and expertise positively impact both students and colleagues.

-Deb Cale

I would like to extend my sincere thanks to our preschool associates for the incredible support, kindness, and care they show our preschool students each and every day. Their smiles, dedication, and unwavering commitment to our young learners do not go unnoticed. They create an environment where students feel safe, supported, and valued, helping to build a strong foundation for learning. The compassion and patience they demonstrate daily make a meaningful difference in the lives of our students and families. Our preschool community is truly fortunate to have such kind and caring individuals helping to shape the educational journey of our youngest learners and setting the stage for their future success.

Nicki Acton, Hannah Barnett, Kim Broekemeier, Carie Burgher, LeAnn Campbell, Amy Dutchuk, Kathi Fox, Cassandra Green, Emma Karns, Sara Little, Deb Nichols, Sarah Ofstad, Amanda Patras, Val Rich, Corinne Rowe, Bambi Schlenker

-Deb Cale

I would like to recognize Jenn Haack for her passion for student learning and her unwavering commitment to supporting students. She is never afraid to take on challenging situations and consistently demonstrates flexibility and preparedness in meeting the needs of every learner who enters her classroom. Jenn welcomes students with an open and supportive approach, ensuring they feel included and cared for. She also does an excellent job training and guiding the associates in her classroom so that students receive the appropriate supports they need to be successful. Jenn consistently goes above and beyond to support both students and staff. Her dedication, teamwork, and positive approach make a meaningful impact on our preschool program. We are very fortunate to have Jenn as part of our preschool team.

-Deb Cale

I would like to celebrate one of the newest members of our preschool teaching team, Kensila Manley. Kensila radiates positivity and brings an enthusiastic focus to meeting the learning needs of her students. She creates a nurturing environment while also maintaining high expectations that encourage students to grow and reach their full potential. Kensila has quickly become a valued member of our team. She has been a joy to work with and has built strong, positive connections with families, helping them feel welcomed and supported in their child's early learning journey. We are grateful to have Kensila as part of our preschool team and appreciate the energy, care, and dedication she brings to our students and school community.

-Deb Cale

I'd like to recognize Kylie Brown, Steph Schultes and Esthela Perez for going above and beyond in helping our SP Kindergarten team be prepared for the rest of the school year amongst the changes we've had to go through. I'm grateful for their hard work and constant collaboration to ensure all our Kindergarten students are successful.

-Katherine Southmayd

I'd like to thank Elyse Webb for ALL the help in organizing assessments during PLC time. We TRULY couldn't have done it without you! I appreciate your support and encouragement with problem solving with students too.

-Katherine Southmayd

I would like to celebrate Amanda Scarboro for her dedication to supporting her students in meaningful and purposeful ways. She is always striving to strengthen the teaching and learning in her classroom and thoughtfully takes feedback and new learning back to her practice to continually improve instruction. Amanda brings a positive and friendly presence to our school community. She interacts with colleagues, students, and families in a respectful and supportive manner, helping to build strong relationships. She is also an excellent collaborative team member who works well with others to support student success. Amanda's commitment to growth, teamwork, and student learning makes a meaningful difference for those around her.

-Deb Cale

I would like to honor and recognize Stephanie Birmingham for her exceptional leadership, initiative, and the invaluable support she provides to the entire preschool team. Stephanie is quick to jump in wherever help is needed and consistently ensures that the team stays organized and focused. She is always looking for ways to improve efficiency and effectiveness, taking the lead in developing innovative strategies to support both students and staff. Her dedication, problem-solving skills, and proactive approach make a meaningful difference in the daily operations of our preschool program. I deeply appreciate Stephanie's guidance and support—her contributions are integral to the success of our team, and I am not sure what we would do without her!

-Deb Cale

I have so appreciated the support from Shana Olson this year. She's done walkthroughs in our building, supported our literacy team and professional development, helped with our Kindergarten kickstart at the beginning of the year and was able to then know some students that needed a "parent" at the Kinder Valentine program. She stepped right in and filled that role. We are extremely grateful for her collaborative approach. The support is definitely felt and appreciated.

-Patty Morris

For Shana Olson:

The first- and second-year mentoring seminars have been impactful and beneficial for both mentees and mentors. Oftentimes, I walk away having learned something new, and I'm nearly at year 10. Thank you for all the hard work you put into the program to make it a meaningful use of time for all parties!

-Ivy Soener

I would like to commend Deb Cale for her outstanding leadership, kindness, and unwavering support. Deb always leads with integrity, compassion and a genuine commitment to both students and staff. I am so grateful for her friendship and leadership and she will be greatly missed at DCE.

-Stephanie Madsen

I would like to say THANK YOU to Courtney Anderson, Megan Kimrey, Abby Crannell, Lisa Shaffer, Emily Drey, Molly Kremer and Leah Mertz for taking a Friday afternoon to reflect on our work through the SAMi process. These AMAZING leaders offered valuable reflection, input, and guidance for future goals and actions of Heritage Elementary.

-Diann Williamson

THANK YOU, Dr. Carenza, for facilitating our SAMI learning on Friday! Your patience and guidance were key in helping us honestly reflect on our practices at Heritage.

-Diann Williamson

THANK YOU, Nicole Jespersen, Hannah Clark, and Emily Drey for being such remarkable teammates and providing support to the substitute teacher! You helped make a difference for lots of kids! This is just one of the many reasons I have loved being a part of the Heritage staff.

-Diann Williamson

Brooke Pfaltzgraff is an exceptional SPED teacher that consistently advocates for the needs of all students. She makes sure they feel supported and heard in a calm, steady way. Brooke has innovative ideas that help students access learning in ways that work best for them. Brooke has a true commitment to inclusion and you can feel how much she loves doing what she does!

-Brittany Halsrud

I would like to commend Tammy Tegtmeier for the support she provides in the middle school health office. I truly appreciate her willingness to step in when I am out of the office, in a meeting, or attending to other student health needs. Her reliability, kindness, and dedication help ensure that students continue to receive the care and attention they need. Her support is greatly appreciated.

-Cara Piepho

*I would like to recognize Health Associate **Brittany Halsrud** for the exceptional care, dedication, and compassion she provides to the students and staff at Dallas Center Elementary. Her calm and reassuring presence helps students feel comfortable during moments when they may be anxious or not feeling well. Her patience, and tireless support play a vital role in creating a safe and nurturing environment where students can learn and thrive. Thank you, Brittany!*

-Cara Piepho

Hannah Klatt,

Thank you for always being on top of your game and doing everything you can to help support your kiddo and staff! You are a team player and valued in so many ways!

-Hannah Clark

Tome Hope,

Thank you for always remaining positive throughout the tough moments and days! You bring the calm to the team that we need at times!

-Hannah Clark

Emma Evans,

Thank you for being flexible in wherever schedules take you! You work so hard with your kids and they are lucky (as well as us) to have you!

-Hannah Clark

Didi Van,

Thank you for jumping right in and being a shining light in our room! You picked up a complex system and ever changing programming with ease and I admire that so much!

-Hannah Clark

Megan Sing,

Thank you for being ready to always take on the day and our kids. Thank you for always holding the kids accountable for their choices and work.

-Hannah Clark

Miranda McVey,

Thank you for hanging in there each day as we work to provide the best programming for some of our highest need kiddos. Plans like these only work with teamwork and I am happy to have that with you!

-Hannah Clark

Jenna Krause,

Even though I don't get to see you as much anymore I know that your kiddo is in the greatest hands possible! You have helped move mountains for that friend! Thank you for always being positive about jumping in to help wherever we need it!

-Hannah Clark

Bella Tamburo,

Thank you for being proactive with your kiddos to help support them the best that we can!

Thank you for always bringing the smiles and laughter when we desperately need it at times!

-Hannah Clark

I would like to send a commendation to Shauna and Jasmine, our administrative assistants in the main office at the high school: Shauna and Jasmine are the heartbeat of our office, ensuring that every day runs as smoothly as possible for students, staff, and families. Their professionalism, organization, and calm problem-solving keep us all moving in the right direction. They often identify issues before anyone else even realizes support is needed. They greet everyone with kindness and patience while managing an incredible workload behind the scenes. Our school is better and more welcoming because of the dedication and care Shauna and Jasmine bring to their work each day. Thank you!

-Sheila Hudson

Thanks to Steven Hopper for helping us get a device set up for a new student at South Prairie. We appreciate all that you do!

-Jenny Rants

Jeff Wolfe and Wednesday School Bus Drivers - Jeff has been working with us to do Wednesday Schools to support our students in getting their missing work completed. His support in helping make sure every kid who needs this opportunity for academic support is incredibly important. Without the chance for kids to get a ride home from our transportation this would have to be a voluntary effort of parents, which is challenging with work schedules. He coordinates with us, finds willing bus drivers to take on extra routes, and creates a bussing route for each individual student. It is a lot of extra work. His communication and willingness to continue this additional work load is so very appreciated not just by our counseling and administration staff, but also by the teachers who don't have to work extra to chase down missing assignments, and the families who can be assured their student is getting homework support as well as a ride home.

-Sarah Rose and Emily Waugh

Jeff Cain Special Education Teacher - Jeff has been so instrumental in taking on changes this year to his daily schedule. Moving rooms, changing his caseload, altering his daily schedule, and being flexible with every challenge thrown his direction. Truly doing what he can to support his students. Thank you for your flexibility and your unwavering support this year during some challenging days!

-Sarah Rose and Emily Waugh

A huge thank you goes out to Kendra Shuckahosee for opening up your classroom and welcoming a group of visiting teachers to see your amazing MyView Literacy lessons in action! Especially the day before spring break and during conference week! You really went the extra mile! We were all impressed to see the way you engaged the students so completely in their learning, the follow-up questions you asked that caused them to go deeper with their thinking was powerful, and you are implementing MyView so creatively! The students were achieving at high levels, and that was exciting to see! Your vulnerability, courage, and flexibility is much appreciated!!

-Tyra Behnkendorf

I would like to recognize Amanda Christiansen. She coordinated the American Legion of Iowa Fifth Grade Flag Essay contest for our students in the Middle School. She collected essays from students and connected them with the Legions of both Dallas Center and Grimes. We are lucky enough to have the state winner in our district. So thank you to Amanda for getting this organized. We appreciate YOU!

-Stacy Heidemann

To all the associates: Amy, Melissa, Shayla, Megan, Katie, Delilah, Danielle, Erika, Deanna, Alysia, Kam, Sherie, Jeanette, Traci, Rhonda, Lori, Paige, Kiirsten, and Mary at North Ridge thank you for ALL you do! I would not be able to do my job without the help of you. You are all amazing and I appreciate everything you do for the students and teachers at North Ridge.

-Courtney Hixenbaugh

Steph Rupp, thank you for all you do with our students. I appreciate the teamwork. :)

-Courtney Hixenbaugh

I would like to recognize Mindy Greiman, Claire Marchant, and Molly Sorenson for their incredible support while I was away on maternity leave. They collaborated with my long-term substitute to ensure she had everything she needed to be successful while I was gone. I am forever grateful for this amazing team!

-Ashley Zimmerman

I would like to recognize my long-term substitute, Tara Johansen for her incredible support while I was on maternity leave. Her level of professionalism, care, and expertise is unmatched. It truly meant the world to me that I was able to focus on my family knowing that she was leading my classroom of students in my absence. Thanks to her my students grew in all areas and are absolutely thriving! You are the best, Tara!

-Ashley Zimmerman

Thank you to the K-12 Art Teachers (Amy Cory, Maddie Maddock, Amanda Erps, Ashley Kolum, Mikayla Everman, April Busch, and Danell Duncan) for all of their hard work and dedication to support students' visual arts education at DCG! This year they have observed art programs in other districts, bringing back valuable insights to strengthen their practice. Their efforts make a meaningful impact on the engaging, supportive, and creative learning experiences provided for students each day!

-Jessica Soukup

I would like to recognize Barb Kellner. Barb is a hardworking, dedicated teacher who is always doing what is best for her students. She puts a lot of care and thought into her work. She has a way of looking at challenges with a positive mindset, does a great job supporting herself and the people around her and helps create a space where others feel valued and appreciated. Thanks for all you do, Barb!

-Michaela Peters

I would like to recognize Oak View's Mrs. Dani Christensen for the amazing work she does day in and day out. She is a wealth of knowledge for students AND staff. Dani has created a warm, welcoming environment in the Oak View Library. She is always willing to help or lend an ear, and our students adore her. We are lucky to have Dani at Oak View!

-Emily Waugh

I would like to commend Cody Milburn. He recently changed hours so our classrooms could be sanitized on a daily basis. He also wipes off all door handles and fixtures daily. This will help with cutting down on illness here at North Ridge. He also has a great work ethic and the kids love to see him in the halls.

-Darla Van Kooten

I would like to commend Linn Coellner for the great work he is doing at North Ridge. His ability to look around and see what needs to be done, his friendliness, his punctuality and work ethic are above and beyond.

-Darla Van Kooten

Shea Jorgensen: I am so glad you joined our team here at DCE! I did not have a kindergarten partner my first year of teaching, so I feel incredibly blessed to call you my kindergarten partner this year. Your love for teaching is inspiring, and I have absolutely loved having the opportunity to co-teach with you. I have learned so much from you!

-Klaire Jungling

Bekah Frisk: I feel incredibly blessed to have you in my room this year! You are the perfect person for our kindergarten friend, and I appreciate you going above and beyond to help all students in my room. You deeply care about each and every kiddo, and you are extremely supportive to me as a teacher. Thanks for all you do and for being such a caring figure in our room!

-Klaire Jungling

As the parent of Hannah Davison, I would like to recognize Shea Jorgensen, Miss Carrie, and Miss Cathy. Mrs. Jorgensen is such a positive light in my child's kindergarten journey. Mrs. Jorgensen shares her passion for learning with her students as well as her patience and kindness. We are so thankful the elementary school offered the kindergarten and first grade combo class this year. We feel our child has gained a growth of knowledge in Reading, Writing and Math she will need to be successful in First grade. Thank you to all the teacher aides as well. They work tirelessly to provide every child with a positive learning experience as well as a kind smile and hug on their tough days. Our community is so blessed to have you!

-Brad and Amanda Davison

As the Parent of Emma Davison, I would like the board to recognize Justine Draisey. Mrs. Draisey has been such a positive light in my daughter's life. We are so fortunate to have experienced her wealth of knowledge, passion for teaching, and deep understanding as to what a third grader needs to grow and achieve more. My daughter looks forward to Math and station work. She says, " Mrs. Draisey is so funny and I love her jokes. " She has grown so much this year in her writing and reading due to Mrs. Draisey's patience and guidance. Thank you Mrs. Draisey and the wonderful staff at Dallas Center Elementary.
-Brad and Amanda Davison

Thank you to Shayla Auten, Amy Dickkut, and Melissa Dodd for being a team that works together closely and has a shared commitment to supporting student success.
-April Heitland

Thank you to Katie Horrigan for her calm and consistent approach, which creates a supportive and stable environment for our students. Her dedication to fostering independence and growth empowers students to build confidence and reach their full potential.
-April Heitland

Thank you to Paige Herbsleb for her strong collaboration, commitment to high expectations, and dedication to student success. She consistently fosters independence and growth, empowering students to take ownership of their learning and reach their full potential.
-April Heitland

Thank you to Danielle House who works closely with the classroom teachers, special education teachers, and encore staff to foster an inclusive environment for her student.
-April Heitland

Thank you to Travis Donahue for his leadership, collaboration and communication to move our district and building forward. His planning and focus on the future is much appreciated.
-April Heitland